

SIBILANCE

Repeating soft "s" and "sh" sounds



1 What is it?

Sibilance (SIB-ih-lunss)

Sibilance is a special type of alliteration that repeats **soft, hissing sounds** — usually "s", but also "sh", "z" or "c" — to create a smooth, whispery, or sometimes sinister effect.

Repeated + "s" / "sh" + sounds

2 See it in action

Something sinister

The snake slid silently through the sleeping grass.

A calm scene

The soft sea sighed against the sandy shore.

In poetry

She whispered secrets in the hush of the classroom.

For tension

A hiss of static crackled from the old speakers.



Keep going!

Read the sentence out loud and listen for that **hissing "sss"** sound — if it's there, always check whether it feels calm or menacing in context.

FUN FACT

Sibilance is often used in horror writing on purpose — the hissing sound is instinctively unsettling to us, a bit like the warning hiss of a snake or an angry cat.

3 Why writers use it

Sibilance helps writers: mimic real sounds like whispering, hissing, or the sea — sibilance can make a scene feel calm and soothing, OR tense and sinister, depending on the context around it.

The same "s" sound can work two completely opposite ways: it can sound like a gentle breeze, or like a threatening snake — the surrounding words tell the reader which one to feel.

4 Don't mix it up!

Sibilance

- Only "s" / "sh" sounds
- "Sea shells shine"
- Feels hissing or whispery

Alliteration

- ANY repeated consonant sound
- "Big blue balloon"
- Broader technique overall



Watch out!

Remember: sibilance is a *type* of alliteration, not a separate thing entirely — so if you spot repeated "s" sounds, it's correct (and more precise) to call it sibilance rather than just alliteration.



Mfalme says...

For top marks, name it precisely as "**sibilance**" rather than just "alliteration" — examiners reward that extra layer of technical accuracy.

5 Quick recap

Repeats "s" / "sh" sounds

A type of alliteration

Can feel calm OR sinister



Look here!

Try writing one calm sentence and one creepy sentence, both using lots of "s" sounds — same technique, totally different effect!